

Mission-Ready Innovation: An Operator's Field Guide to the Product Approach

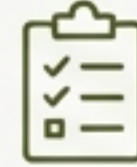
Adapting California's Proven Methodologies for the Air National Guard



California Office of
Data and Innovation

Enhancing Readiness Through Smarter Operations

Situation Report



The Challenge

Manual processes, data silos, and legacy systems create operational friction. They consume valuable time and hinder real-time decision-making.

Direct Evidence

> *"Military Department planners manually track mission-ready resources, **missing critical real-time data on availability and deployment impact, which hinders decision-making** when assessing the readiness of personnel and equipment ahead of unit activation."*

The Impact

This operational friction directly affects our ability to assess readiness, deploy resources efficiently, and execute the mission at the required speed.



A Proven Playbook for Solving Complex Problems

What It Is: “The ‘Product Approach’ is the State of California’s standardized, human-centered methodology for building better services and processes. It’s not just for technology; it’s a way of thinking about mission execution.”



User-Focused

“Fall in love with the problem, not the solution.” Solutions are designed for and validated by the Airmen who will use them.



Iterative

Start small, test, learn, and improve. This avoids lengthy projects that fail to deliver mission value.



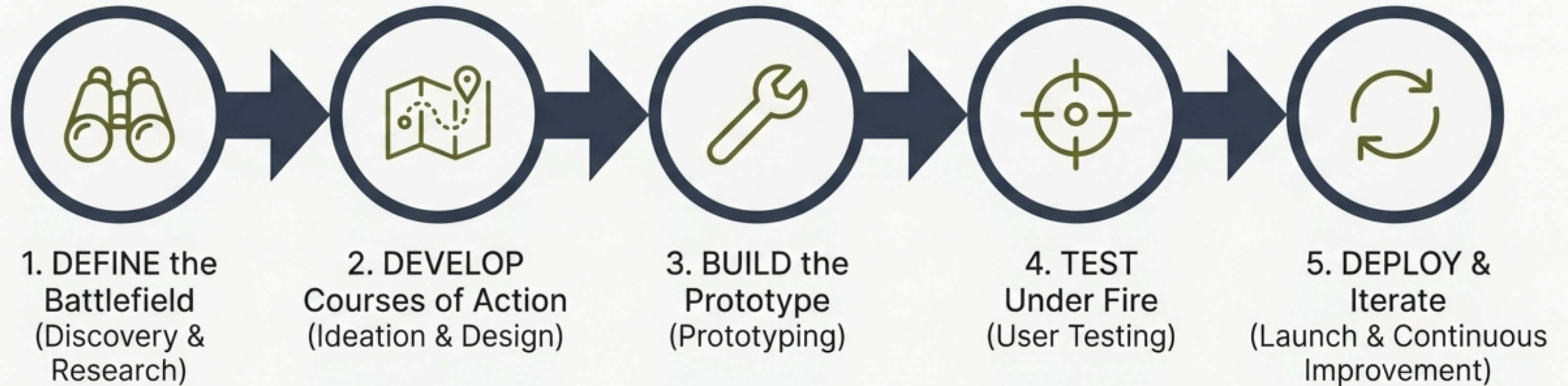
Data-Driven

Use evidence and direct feedback to make decisions, not assumptions.

Proof Point

The Governor’s Innovation Fellows program uses this exact approach to tackle the state’s toughest challenges. The California Military Department is an active participant, with Fellows like SMSgt Blake E. Carter (ANG) helping lead the way.

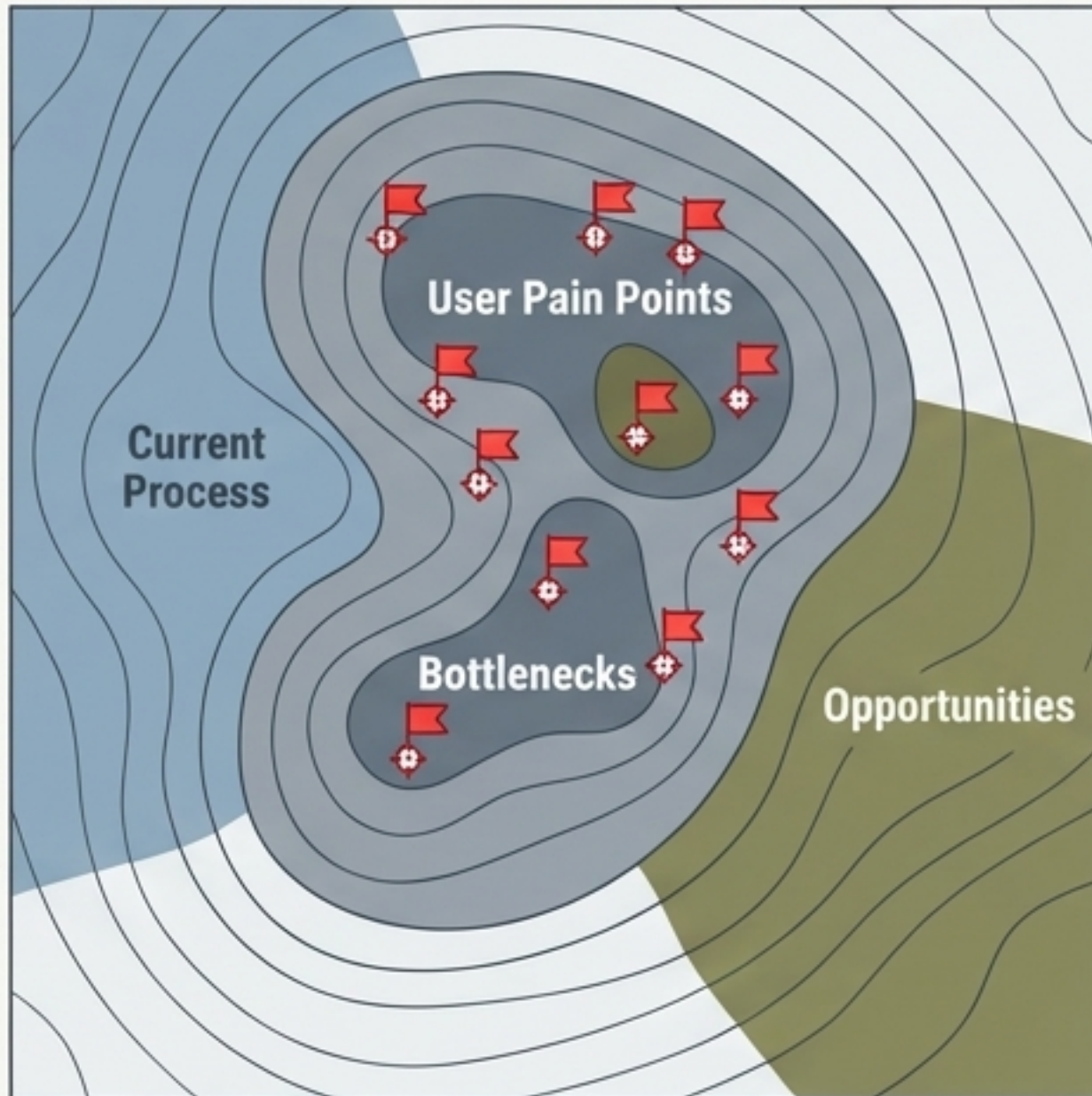
The Execution Framework: From Problem to Deployed Solution



This structured, repeatable process reduces risk and ensures the final solution meets the actual needs of the mission and the operator.

Phase 1: DEFINE the Battlefield

To deeply understand the problem from the perspective of the people who live it every day.



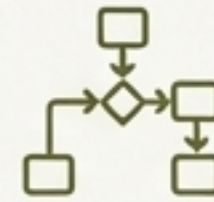
Key Activities



- **Assemble the Team:** Form a cross-functional group of 3-5 people, including front-line staff (the user), program staff (the expert), and IT (if applicable).



- **Identify Your Users:** Define who uses the process. Think in terms of "most" (75%), "some" (20%), and "a few" (<5%) to ensure all needs, especially for the most vulnerable users, are considered.



- **Process Map the Service:** Visually map every step of the current process, from request to completion. Identify every pain point and bottleneck.



- **Conduct SME Interviews:** Talk to the Subject Matter Experts. Structure conversations to uncover key insights on pain points, perceived value, risks, and opportunities.

Phase 2: DEVELOP Courses of Action

Objective: To generate, evaluate, and select a potential solution to prototype.

Key Activities:



- **Brainstorm Solutions:** Based on the “Battlefield” map, sketch multiple potential solutions. Avoid settling on the first idea.



- **Draft a “Design Brief”:** A one-page document that outlines the mission. Key components include: Background, Problem Statement, Key Success Metrics, Scope (what's in, what's out), and the Minimum Viable Product (MVP).



- **Prioritize with an Outcomes Matrix:** Formally weigh alternative solutions against critical criteria. This ensures the chosen path is the most effective.

Outcomes Matrix: Resource Tracking			
	Impact on Readiness	Speed to Implement	Cost
New Dashboard	++↑	-→	--↓
Automated Report	+↑	++↑	+↑

Build to Learn, Test to Win

To quickly create a tangible version of the solution and get real feedback from users before investing significant time and money.

Phase 3: BUILD the Prototype



This is not the final product. It can be a paper sketch, a clickable digital mockup, or a revised paper form.

The goal is to make the idea real enough for an operator to interact with and provide meaningful feedback.

Phase 4: TEST Under Fire



Put the prototype in the hands of the Airmen who will actually use the final product. Observe what works and what doesn't. Listen to their feedback.

We are testing our material, not you.

Case Study: DMV Application Redesign

During the DMV driver's license application redesign, simple user testing revealed a critical flaw. Users, seeing "Alzheimer's" and "Diabetes" at the top of a medical list, assumed they had no conditions and checked "no" for everything, including for wearing corrective lenses. Reordering the questions based on this feedback prevented countless errors.

Before

- ☐ Alzheimer's Disease
- ☐ Diabetes
- ☐ Medical Conditions
- ☐ Do you require Conditions
- ☐ Conditions
- ☐ Contact & Glasses
- ☐ Nachardone

After

- ☐ Do you require corrective lenses?
- ☐ Alzheimer's Disease
- ☐ Diabetes
- ☐ Medical Conditions
- ☐ Do you require Conditions
- ☐ Conditions
- ☐ Contact & Glasses

Phase 5: DEPLOY & Iterate

Phase 5

Objective: To get the solution into the field and establish a process for continuous improvement based on real-world data.

Key Activities:



Beta Test (Soft Launch): Release the new process or tool to a small, controlled group of actual users. This allows you to monitor data in near real-time and fix common errors *before* a full launch.



Revisit the Process: A solution is a living document. Re-evaluate it periodically. Have user needs changed? Has the mission evolved?

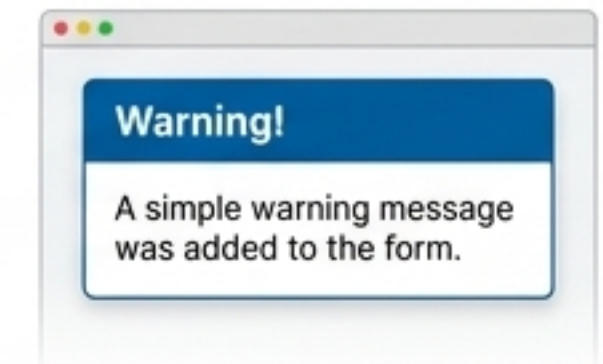
Proof of Concept - The SUN Bucks Application

The Problem

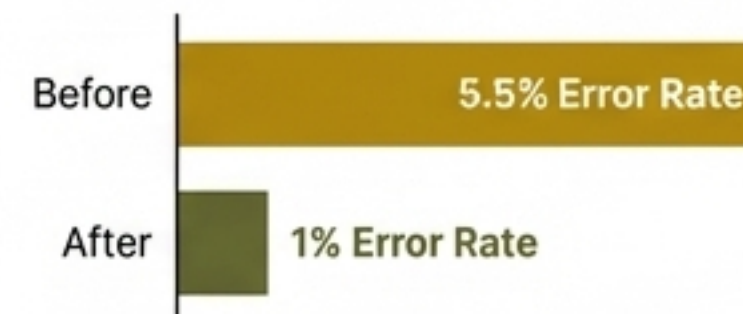


During a soft launch, data showed that 5% of users were accidentally failing to mark anyone in their household as a student, making them ineligible.

The Fix



The Result



Result: An estimated **630 families saved** from being incorrectly denied benefits.

Communicate with Clarity and Purpose

The Problem

Government and military communication is often filled with jargon, acronyms, and passive voice. This creates confusion, leads to errors, and wastes time.

DON'T SAY

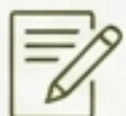
"The application must be completed by the applicant and received by the financial office by June 1st."

****Reading Level: Grade 13****

SAY

"We must get your application by June 1."

****Reading Level: Grade 2****



The Standard - Plain Language

- Use small, common words. Write in short sentences.
- Use "you" and "we" with an active voice.
- Aim for an 8th-grade reading level for broad communications to ensure maximum comprehension.



The Benefit

Clear instructions lead to correct actions. This reduces errors, saves man-hours, and builds trust.

Building Buy-In and Managing Change

The Reality: Change is difficult. Acknowledging and planning for resistance is critical to mission success.

A Framework for Action



Identify Resistance: Use surveys, focus groups, and one-on-one check-ins to understand concerns. Don't wait for problems to surface.



Understand the Root Cause: Is resistance due to a lack of information? Fear of a skill gap? Perceived loss of control?



Address it Directly: Use a targeted "Intervention Matrix" to deploy the right solution for the specific problem.

Tactics and Examples

Example Intervention

Root Cause:
Fear of Skill Gap



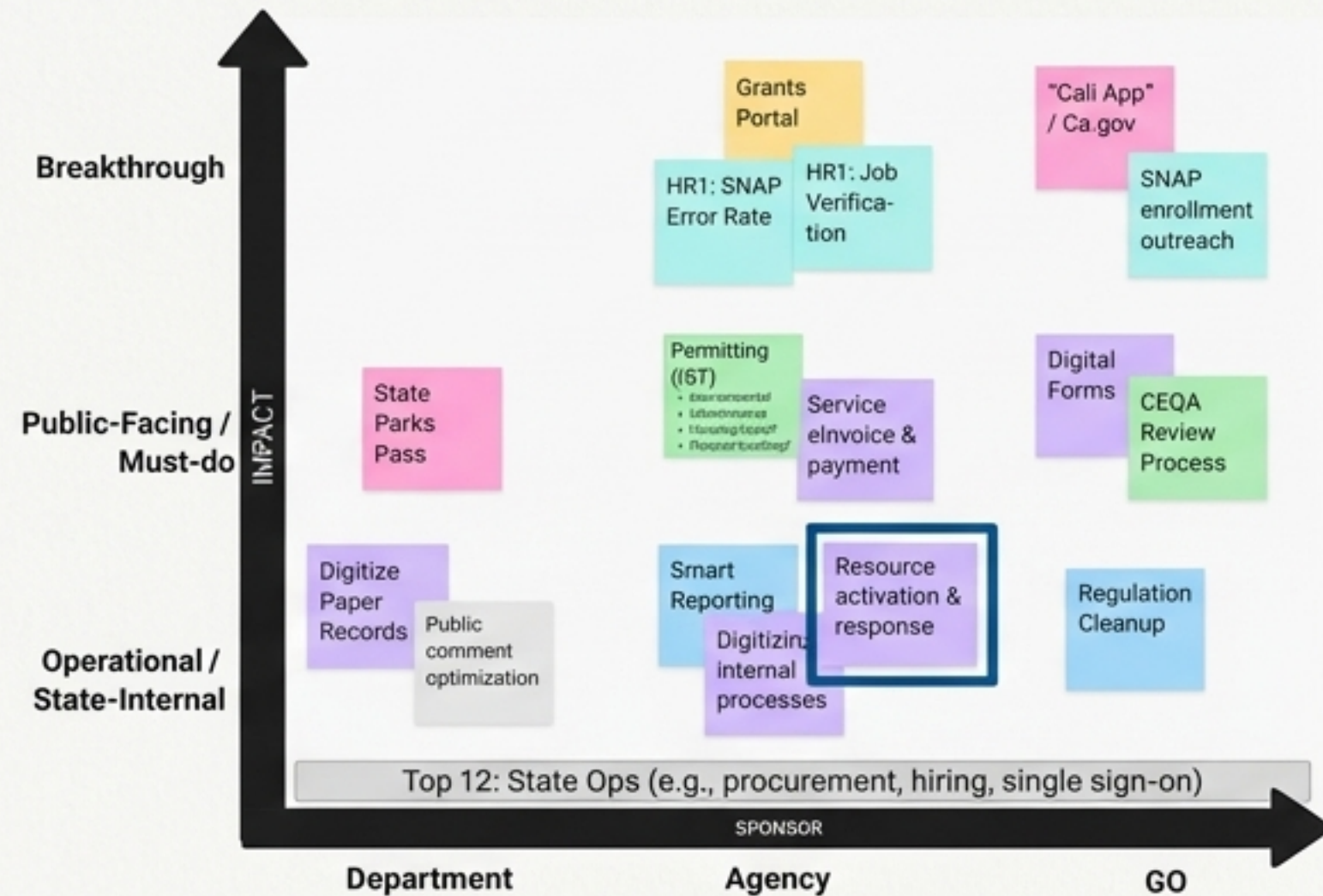
Intervention: Provide customized hands-on training workshops, peer mentoring opportunities, and job shadowing.



Key Tactic

Create a "Change Agent Network" of empowered champions within units to advocate for the new approach and provide peer support.

The Product Approach in Action: CMD Resource Readiness



"Military Department planners manually track mission-ready resources, missing critical real-time data on availability and deployment impact, which hinders decision-making when assessing the readiness of personnel and equipment ahead of unit activation."

Applying the 5-Phase Mission Plan



1. Define Battlefield

Interview planners, unit commanders, and logisticians. Map the current manual tracking process and identify all pain points.



2. Develop COAs

Sketch potential dashboards vs. automated reporting tools. Create a Design Brief for the chosen path.



3. Build Prototype

Create a clickable mockup of a readiness dashboard using a tool like PowerBI.



4. Test Under Fire

Give the prototype to planners and ask them to use it to answer a time-sensitive readiness question. Observe where they struggle.



5. Deploy & Iterate

Launch a beta version for one Wing, gather feedback, and improve before a statewide rollout.

If You Can't Measure It, You Can't Improve It

Focusing on What Matters: From Outputs to Outcomes

An Output is what we did



We built a digital readiness dashboard.



An Outcome is why it mattered



...so that commanders have real-time visibility into force readiness, **reducing decision time for unit activation by 50%.**

Key Performance Indicators (KPIs) for the ANG



Time

Reduction in man-hours for manual reporting; faster deployment timelines.



Cost

Dollars saved on inefficient processes; improved resource allocation.



Quality

Higher accuracy in readiness data; reduction in process error rates.



Readiness

A direct and measurable link to improved metrics in key readiness reports.

Your First Mission: Identify a Target

You don't need a massive project to start. Begin with a single, high-friction process that is a known "pain point."

1. **Find the Friction:** What is a process, form, or system that consistently frustrates your Airmen and slows down the mission? (e.g., travel vouchers, training requests, equipment check-out).
2. **Assemble a Small Team:** Grab 2-3 motivated colleagues who know the problem intimately.
3. **Draft a Design Brief:** Use the one-page template to define the problem, scope the project, and identify what success looks like.

Offer of Support: The Office of Data and Innovation (ODI) and your CMD Innovation Fellows are available as a resource to help you launch your first effort.

DESIGN BRIEF

 **Problem Statement**

 **Key Success Metrics / Outcomes**
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 **Scope: In / Out**

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 **Minimum Viable Product (MVP)**
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 **Stakeholders**
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Continue the Mission: Resources & Points of Contact

Key Resources

[Full “Field Guide to Fix Government Forms”](#)

[ODI “Ongoing Product Approach Curriculum”](#)

[Templates for Design Briefs, Process Maps, and User Testing Scripts](#)

Internal CMD Points of Contact

SMSgt Blake E. Carter, California Air National Guard

Jai London, Services Procurement Supervisor, CMD

SSG Kelton Pisano, Emergency Finance Specialist, CMD

State-Level Support

Office of Data and Innovation (ODI)

Email:
CalAcademy@innovation.ca.gov

Mission-Ready Innovation



CALIFORNIA OFFICE OF
DATA & INNOVATION

NotebookLM